

KILLER GRIP

Rhomaleosaurus used its cone-shaped fangs to attack large prey. Like a crocodile, it may have twisted its victims around violently to tear their bodies apart and make them easier to swallow.

CAMOUFLAGE

Like large sea animals today, *Rhomaleosaurus* may have had a pale belly and a dark back. This pattern, known as countershading, is a type of camouflage—it makes marine animals harder to see both from above and below.

Rhomaleosaurus

ROME-alley-oh-SORE-us



- **When** 200–195 million years ago (Early Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** England, Germany
- **Habitat** Coastal waters
- **Length** 15–21 ft (5–7 m)
- **Diet** Fish, squid, and ocean reptiles



Rhomaleosaurus was a plesiosaur—a type of plesiosaur with a short neck. It hunted by sight and smell, perhaps allowing seawater to flow through its mouth and out of its nostrils so it could pick up the scent of prey. Fossilized remains of food in the bellies of plesiosaurs reveal that their diet included squid, fish, and other plesiosaurs.

EARLY VERTEBRATES



► FLIPPER

Rhomaleosaurus swam by beating its four powerful flippers, using them like wings to “fly” through the water in the same way as penguins move underwater today.

